



The Pearls of The Sea

Caviar, that rare food, is considered the epitome of fine dining. Here is everything that you need to know about it

BY RAAJ SANGHVI

THERE ARE FEW foods in the world with as much of a mystique as caviar. For decades it was viewed as an extravagance that always felt a little out of reach, both in terms of taste and price. But that era is behind us. Today, caviar has shed its aura of unattainability and is undergoing a renaissance, popping up on fine-dining menus around the world with surprising regularity. If you think caviar is just fish eggs, you're only partially right, because not all roe qualifies for this glorious title. The term caviar is reserved for the roe (eggs) of the sturgeon, an elusive cartilaginous fish now found all over the world (more on that later). Unlike other roe, which come in various sizes and colours, sturgeon caviar stands out for its rich, buttery taste with a hint of oceanic saltiness. Its charm lies in how each tiny pearl melts and pops on your palate, releasing layers of flavour that are both complex and subtle, with umami taking centre stage.

For centuries, the sturgeon was most commonly found swimming wild in the Caspian Sea, in the waters bordering Iran and what was once the Soviet Union. In fact, for a long time, the Soviets had a near-monopoly over the caviar trade, controlling everything from fishing to extraction, canning, and export. But overfishing eventually caught up, and as the sturgeon population in the Caspian plummeted, so did the supply—driving caviar prices sky high.

Most caviar no longer comes from the Caspian Sea. By the late 20th century, international businessmen saw an opportunity and began investing in caviar farms. Today, nearly all the caviar avail-